back to its roots. In every meeting, he would remind the local workers, ‘This is our big chance, we must not squander it.’

But Shah knew that traditional Hindutva politics could only be one weapon—the real test was in piercing through UP’s byzantine caste arithmetic. The Yadavs were loyal to the SP, Mayawati had cornered the Dalit vote (especially her own Jatav community’s), and the Muslims would not trust the BJP. A new election paradigm was needed.

A massive drive was initiated to register young volunteers from across 13,000 colleges in the state. Around 800 full-time volunteers under the age of thirty were recruited and armed with mobiles with prepaid SIM cards; their prime target was the young voter. ‘We felt that the young voter in UP was most likely to look beyond traditional caste politics. The slogan of parivartan was resonating with them most effectively,’ says a BJP leader involved in planning the strategy.

I had a first-hand experience of this when I met an elderly Yadav in Gorakhpur who said he had been a life-long Mulayam voter but was shifting to the BJP this time. ‘You see, my grandson in Noida is an engineer and he says Modi is the right person for India. *Ab pote ki baat toh sunni padegi!’* (I will have to listen to my grandson), he laughed.

Indeed, the demographic shift in UP’s population—with a large and influential chunk of young voters—would eventually give the BJP an important incremental vote. Just as interesting was the role of economic migrants. Bansal claims that around 15,000 Purvanchalis (eastern UP-ites) based in Mumbai, Bangalore and Ahmedabad returned to UP for the election campaign and spread the ‘Modi for PM’ message among the locals. ‘Even migrant workers from diamond factories in Surat came home and told their community members stories of how Gujarat was prospering under Modi,’ says Bansal.

Not that Shah wasn’t playing his own version of caste politics. In all booths, caste-based clusters were created based on the numerical strength of each caste, and volunteers chosen accordingly. More than eighty caste *sammelan*s (conferences) were held, especially to attract the non-Yadav OBCs and the non-Jatav Dalits. ‘When in UP, do as UP-ites do. If caste